EXERCISES

Writing Tasks

1. How does Earl Wavell relate life and reading? (Guideline: Make the idea of 'human touch' central to the essay; how it is important in life, how it affects the choice of books, the reading habit etc.)
2. Since the essay is on reading, the writer has to be personal. He writes in the first person, and lists his choice. You may or may not have read these books. Write an essay on your idea of reading, the books you like to have in your library/personal collection.

Further Reading

'On Reading' by Francis Bacon
'Prison Studies' by Malcolm X (In *Autobiography of Malcolm*, Random House)
'Survival' by Margaret Atwood (In *Survival: A Thematic Guide to Canadian Literature*, Toronto: House of Anasi Press, 1972)

Apollo-8

Anne Morrow Lindbergh

The Night Before

1 At midnight, we decided to go out to the Cape to see the rocket lit up with searchlights for its final servicing. Already the roads approaching the Cape are full, the sides lined with cars, tents and trailers full of people spending the night on the beach to be in place for the early morning spectacle.

2 Even before we reach the Cape we see Apollo-8 miles away across the water, blazing like a star on the horizon. We journey toward it until we are only a mile or two distant. As we approach, it gets larger and brighter until it dominates the dark landscape, an incandescent tube, a giant torch with searchlights focussed on it and beaming beyond over the heavens. The whole sky is arched with rainbows of light.

3 We climb out of the car and stand in the night wind, facing the source of light. Even at this distance we can see the rocket clearly, poised on its pad and gleaming white. The service structure, one half of its protective sheath, has been pulled away. Only the mobile launcher (the umbilical tower), that dark, bulky crane-like structure, stands beside it, dimmed by its brilliance.

4 For the first time the rocket is alone, whole and free. It is no longer in sections, dwarfed by the mammoth assembly building or obscured by scaffolding. The thousands of details we witnessed this morning have been unified into a single shape we cannot see, except as a dazzling whiteness, the glaze of frost that coats it due to the extreme cold of the liquid fuels it holds. There is just a wisp of vapour curling from one side, like a white plume of breath in the darkness. All is simplified by distance and night into the sheer pure shape of flight, into beauty.

5 Seen from this dark field tonight, it has curiously biological overtones. The mobile launcher, that earthbound structure with

outstretched arms, looks like some gigantic insect. It is turned, almost seems to lean, with its over-hanging crane, above the slightly smaller rocket, in a gesture that is half embrace and half release; while the rocket at its side is newborn, naked, silver-bright. Here is the seed split from its pod, the gleaming chrysalis cracked from its protective cocoon. Here is the new moon in the old moon's arms.

6 But like the newborn there is something astonishingly tender about it. Vulnerable and untried, this is the child of a mechanical womb, of a scientific civilisation—untried, but full of promise. Radiating light over the heavens, it seems to be the focus of the world, as the Star of Bethlehem once was. But what does it promise? What new world? What hope for mortal man struggling on earth?

7 I think of Henry Adams at the turn of the century, standing at a Paris exhibit in front of the towering dynamo. Half awed and half repelled, he tried to weigh the force of the Virgin, who built Chartres, against the challenging force of the new power. The Virgin, he feared, 'the greatest force the Western world had ever felt,' was being displaced by the dynamo. In this light-structure night are we being hypnotised by another 'dynamo?'

8 And yet the symbols that spring to mind—even the words used by the experts—are inescapably human: 'the umbilical tower,' 'the bird perched for flight,' 'the launch window is open.' Can we ever escape from our humanness no matter where we go or what we do?

The Morning of Launching

9 We wake to the alarm at 4:30, and leave our Cocoa Beach motel at 5:15. As we approach the Cape we see again the rocket and its launching tower from far off over the lagoon. It is still illumined with searchlights, but last night's vision has vanished. It is no longer tender or biological, but simply a machine, the newest and most perfected creation of a scientific age—hard, weighty metal.

10 We watch the launching with some of the astronauts and their families, from a site near the Vehicle Assembly Building. Our cars are parked on a slight rise of ground. People get out, walk

about restlessly, set up cameras and adjust their binoculars. The launch pad is about three miles away from us, near the beach. We look across Florida marsh grass and palmettos. A cabbage palm stands up black against a shadowy sky, just left of the rocket and its launching tower. As dawn flushes the horizon, an egret rises and lazily glides across the flats between us and the pad. It is a still morning. Ducks call from nearby inlets. Vapor trails of a high-flying plane turn pink in an almost cloudless sky. Stars pale in the blue.

11 With the morning light, Apollo-8 and its launching tower become clearer, harder and more defined. One can see the details of installation. The dark sections on the smooth sides of the rocket, marking its stages, cut up the single fluid line. Vapor steams furiously off its side. No longer stark and simple, this morning the rocket is complicated, mechanical, earth-bound. Too weighty for flights, one feels.

12 People stop talking, stand in front of their cars and raise binoculars to their eyes. We peer nervously at the launch site and then our wrist watches. Radio voices blare unnaturally loud from car windows. 'Now only 30 minutes to launch time . . . 15 minutes . . . 6 minutes . . . 30 seconds . . . to go . . . 20. . . . T minus 15, 14, 13, 12, 11, 10, 9, . . . Ignition!'

13 A jet of steam shoots from the pad below the rocket, 'Ahhhh.' The crowd gasps, almost in unison. Now great flames, spurt, leap, belch out across the horizon. Clouds of smoke billow up on either side of the rocket, completely hiding its base. From the midst of this holocaust, the rocket begins to rise slowly, as in a dream, so slowly it seems to hang suspended on the cloud of fire and smoke. It's impossible—it can't rise. Yes, it rises, but heavily, as if the giant weight is pulled by an invisible hand out of the atmosphere, like the lead on a plumb line from the depths of the sea. Slowly it rises and because of our distance—silently, like a dream.

14 Suddenly the noise breaks, jumps across our three separating miles—a shattering roar of explosions, a trip-hammer over one's head, under one's feet, through one's body. The earth shakes; cars rattle; vibrations beat in the chest. A roll of thunder, prolonged, prolonged, prolonged.

15 I drop the binoculars and put my hands to my ears, hold my head to keep steady, eyes still fixed on the rocket, mesmerised by its slow ascent.

16 The foreground is now full of birds; a great flock of ducks, herons, small birds rises pell-mell from the marshes at the noise. Fluttering in alarm and confusion, they scatter in all directions as if it were the end of the world. In the seconds I take to look at them the rocket has left the tower.

17 It is up and away, a comet boring through the sky, no longer the vulnerable untried child, no longer the earth-bound machine, or the weight at the end of a line, but sheer terrifying force, blasting upward on its own titanic power.

18 It has gone miles into the sky. It is blurred by a cloud. No, it has made its own cloud—a huge vapour trail, which hides it. Out of the cloud something falls, cart-wheeling down, smoking. 'The first-stage cutoff,' someone says. Where is the rocket itself?

19 There, above the cloud now, reappears the rocket, only a very bright star, diminishing every second. Soon out of sight, off to lunar space.

20 One looks earthward again. It is curiously still and empty. A cloud of brown smoke hangs motionless on the horizon. Its long shadow reaches us across the grass. The launch pad is empty. The abandoned launching tower is being sprayed with jets of water to cool it down. It steams in the bright morning air. Still dazed, people stumble into cars and start the slow, jammed trek back to town. The monotone of radio voices continues. One clings to this last thread of contact with something incredibly beautiful that has vanished.

21 'Where are they—where are they now?' In 11 minutes we get word. They are in earth orbit. They 'look good' in the laconic space talk that comes down from over a hundred miles above earth. And one realises again that it is the men above all that matter, the individuals who man the machine, give it heart, sight, speech, intelligence and direction; and the men on earth who are backing them up, monitoring their every move, even to their heartbeats. This is not sheer power, it is power under control of man.

22 We drive slowly back to town. Above us the white vapour trail of the rocket is being scattered by wind into feathery shapes of heron's wings—the only mark in the sky of the morning's launching.

Dialogue

23 In the days that followed, along with the rest of the world, we watched through television and radio the progress of the spacecraft on its 500,000 miles journey around the moon and back to earth. The voices of the control station at Houston and the voices of the astronauts bounced back and forth from spacecraft to earth, an incredible dialogue almost without interruption over six days and nights. The terse language, made up of astronomical calculations and computerised system checks—as vital as the heartbeats on a stethoscope—was interspersed with the very human comments, impressions, questions, hopes, fears and prayers of three mortals in lunar space:

24 'I'm looking out of my centre window, which is the round window, and the window is bigger than the earth right now'.

'The earth is very bright!'. . .

25 'It is a beautiful, beautiful view with predominantly blue background and just huge covers of clouds . . . . It is very, very beautiful.'

26 'Waters are all sort of a royal blue; clouds, of course, are bright white, the reflection off the earth is much greater than the moon. The land areas are . . . sort of dark brownish to light brown in texture.'

27 'At 180,000 miles out in space . . . what I keep imagining is if I am some lonely traveller from another planet what would I think about the earth at this altitude, whether I think it would be inhabited or not.'

28 'The earth is now passing through my window. It's about as big as the end of my thumb' . . .

'They told us that there is a beautiful moon out there.'

'Now we were just saying that there was a beautiful earth out there' . . .

'It depends on your point of view' . . .

29 'The moon is a different thing to each one of us . . . a vast, lonely, forbidding-type existence, great expanse of nothing . . . clouds and clouds of pumice stone . . . not . . . a very inviting place to live or work' . . .

30 'The vast loneliness up here of the moon is awe-inspiring and it makes you realise just what you have back there on earth' . . .

'The sky up here is also rather forbidding, foreboding extents of blackness'...

'And from the crew of Apollo-8, we pause with good night . . . and God bless all of you . . . all of you on the good earth.'

'I think I must have the feeling that the travellers in the old sailing ships used to have. Going on a very long voyage away from home and now we're headed back and I have the feeling of being proud of the trip, but still happy to be going back home. . . . And that's richer than being right here.'

31 Until finally, on the beginning of the seventh day, the spacecraft pierced through the narrow re-entry corridor, that tiny hole in space, into the earth's atmosphere, trailing a hundred-mile long tail of light as it reached for home and splash down, under blossoming parachutes, into a welcoming Pacific and a cheering world.

32 This overwhelming ovation, not only from the United States, but from the world—what does it mean? What does it express? The acclaim is certainly for the perfection of the flight, each stage and detail of it. America, in a much-needed burst of patriotism, can be justly proud of American achievement and gallantry. But does this explain such a wave of enthusiasm and hope?

33 The witnessing of sheer power is not enough to cause such elation. Sheer power, unleashed at the first atom-bomb explosion, inspired feelings of awe, but not a wave of hope; on the contrary, a sense of foreboding and fear. The supremacy of the machine alone—unmanned vehicles probing even further into the universe did not kindle such expectation. Is mankind cheering the first step in the conquest of space, the material of scientific discoveries that follow, or the cracking open of a new electronic, computerised age? Deeper springs, one suspects, lie beneath our reaction.

34 What lifts our hearts today seems to be more in the realm of the human, the psychological and the spiritual. Our response may

still be too profound to reach the surface of words. Centuries may pass before man will know the promise of Apollo-8, or can assess the true meaning of this age and the new view of man and his planet—a view as revolutionary as the one Galileo illumined with his telescope.

Glossary

para		
3	**poised**	... balanced
4	**mammoth**	... huge
5	**chrysalis**	... transition state (of silkworm)
	cocoon	... case (of silkworm)
9	**lagoon**	... stretch of salt water parted from sea by low sand bank
10	**palmettos**	... dwarf fan-palm
	egret	... white heron (a bird)
13	**belch**	... send out noisily
15	**mesmerised**	... hypnotised
20	**monotone**	... unvaried tone
32	**ovation**	... applause
33	**elation**	... joy
	foreboding	... presentiment

Reference Tasks

Look up the following in an encyclopedia:

1. Henry Adams 2. Star of Bethlehem 3. Virgin of Chartres

Notes and Explanations

The descriptive narration of the launching of the rocket, Apollo 8, has three segments to it. 'The Night Before' paints an impressive picture of the surroundings, the rocket and its launcher with meticulous attention to detail. The parallel to 'humanness' is underscored. The second segment, 'The Morning of Launching' focuses on the launch itself – the expectation, the noise and the powerful blast into space controlled by man. The third section, 'Dialogue' is a 'direct' rendering of the kaleidoscopic impressions of the three travellers in space. The return is celebrated with enthusiasm; the achievement of science has a human and spiritual dimension to it and that is significant.

Apollo 8 was eighth in a series of flights using Apollo-specification hardware, the second manned flight of a Block II spacecraft and the first manned flight to use a Saturn-launch vehicle. In configuration it is very similar to Apollo 7.